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Asia: steering through the fog



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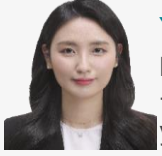
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CHINA

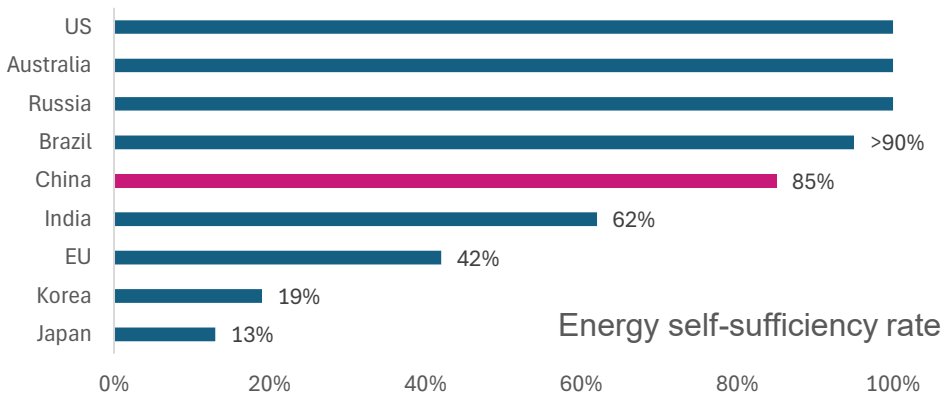
Stability and security

China: manageable impact of the Iran conflict

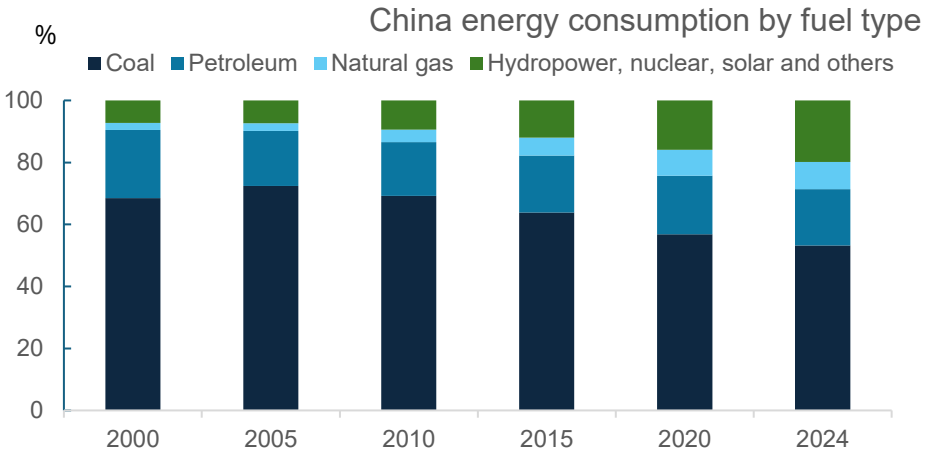
China relatively well positioned to cushion global energy supply shocks

- China's energy self-sufficiency is high (85%), with its primary source of consumption being coal, rapid development of alternatives, diversified oil & gas imports and sizable strategic reserves providing shock mitigation
- China's heavily regulated fuel prices and low oil & gas dependence for electricity generation would help China manage the global energy supply shock better than many other major manufacturer producers
- As a net fuel exporter and major global chemical producer, China would be able to prioritise domestic supply and attract some diversified trade flows

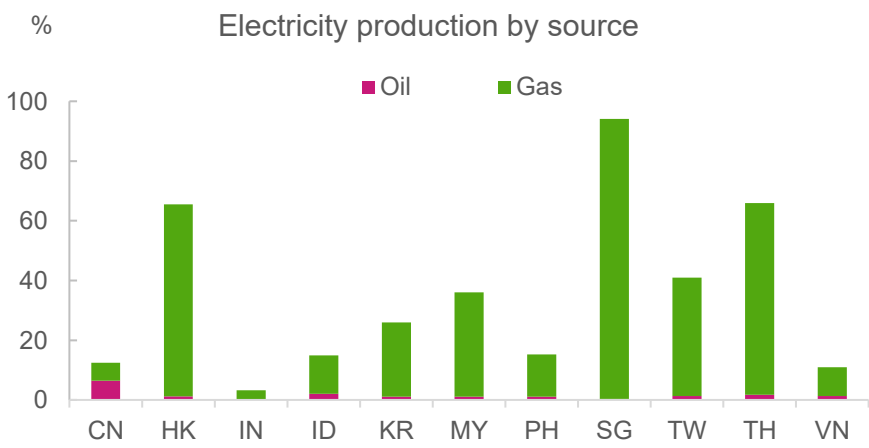
China is a net energy importer but with high self-sufficiency rate



Over 50% of China energy consumption comes from coal



China's low electricity dependence on oil & gas



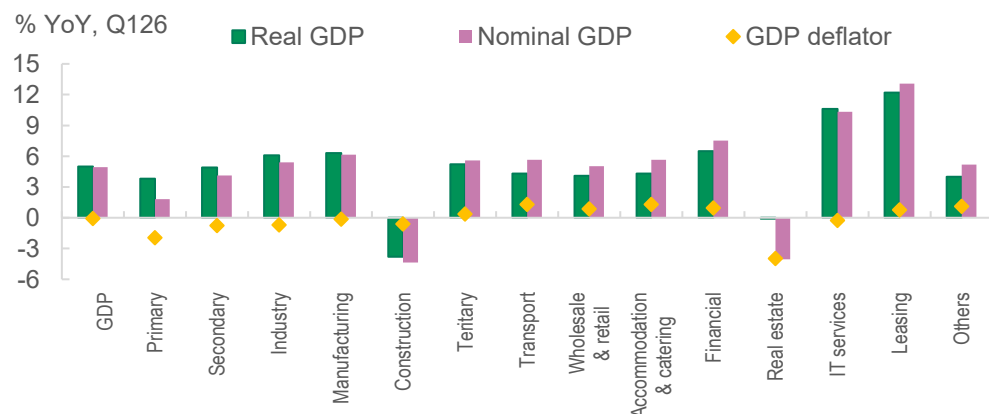
Source all charts: Wind, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

China: a good start to 2026 while Iran risks loom

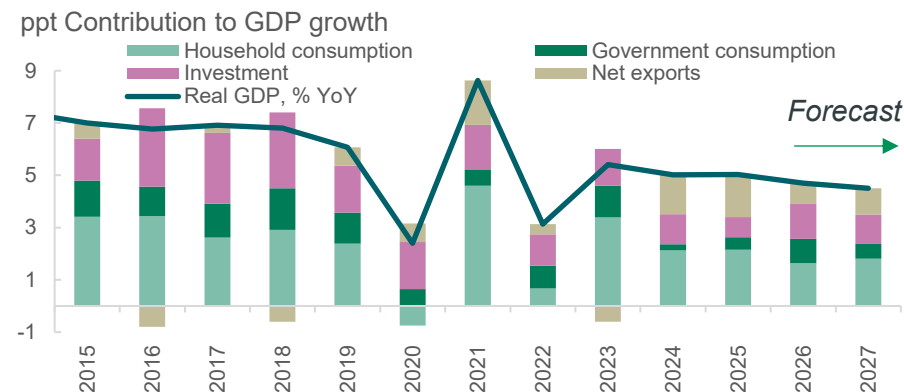
Measured slowdown with modest rebalancing

- China's growth momentum was strong in Q1, despite some trade disruptions on the Iran conflict. GDP growth accelerated to 5.0% YoY in Q1 from 4.5% in Q425, led by high-tech related manufacturing and services
- Share of domestic demand contribution rose notably to 85% on investment rebound. Nominal GDP growth is set to surpass real GDP growth as GDP deflator will likely turn positive starting from Q2
- We maintain our GDP growth forecast at 4.7% in 2026. Downside growth risk primarily rises from the external front, though China's energy security and ample policy room would provide a decent buffer

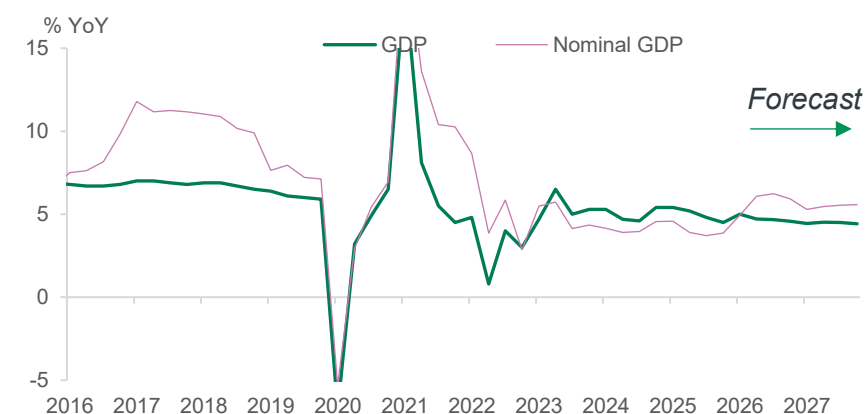
High-tech related manufacturing and services major growth drivers



Domestic demand growth could improve in 2026



Nominal growth to surpass nominal growth in Q2

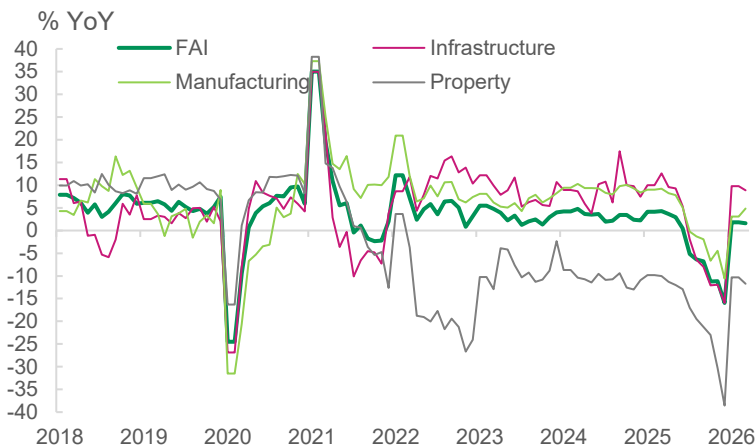


China: uneven domestic recovery and supply-demand divergence

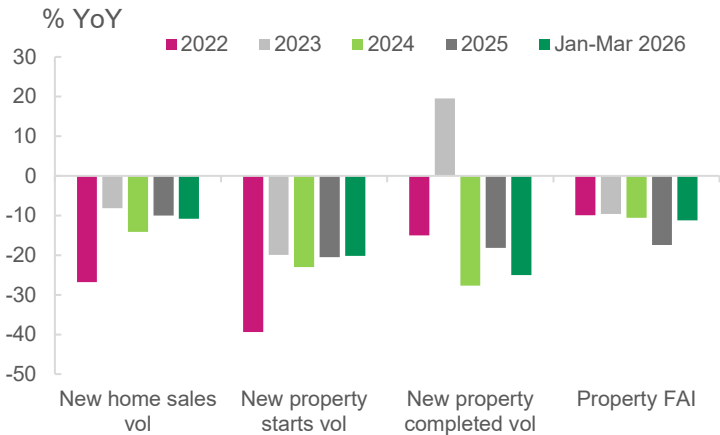
A gradual domestic demand growth recovery, led by investment pick up

- Highlights remained in high-tech manufacturing and infrastructure investment, while property continued to drag headline growth
- Property indicators remained in deep contraction. There have been some signs of improving sentiment in tier-one cities, though it is unlikely broad-based
- We expect a mild and gradual domestic demand growth recovery in 2026. The trend of investment growth improvement to continue, while private consumption growth could remain at a relatively soft level

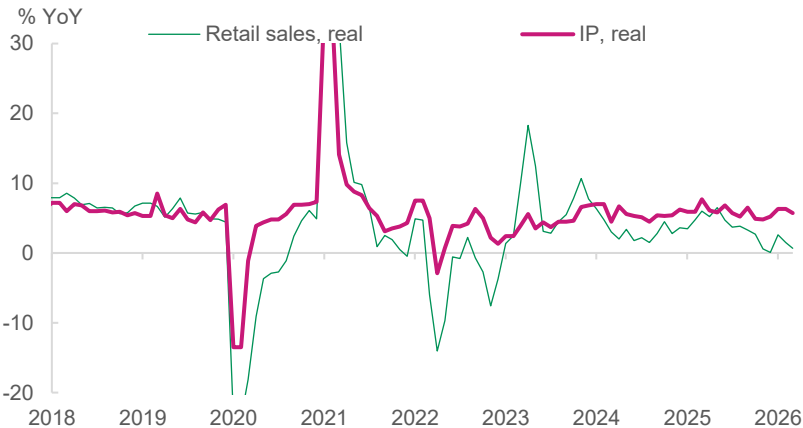
Diverging FAI momentum across different sectors



Major property indicators remained in contraction



Supply-demand divergence with weak consumer demand



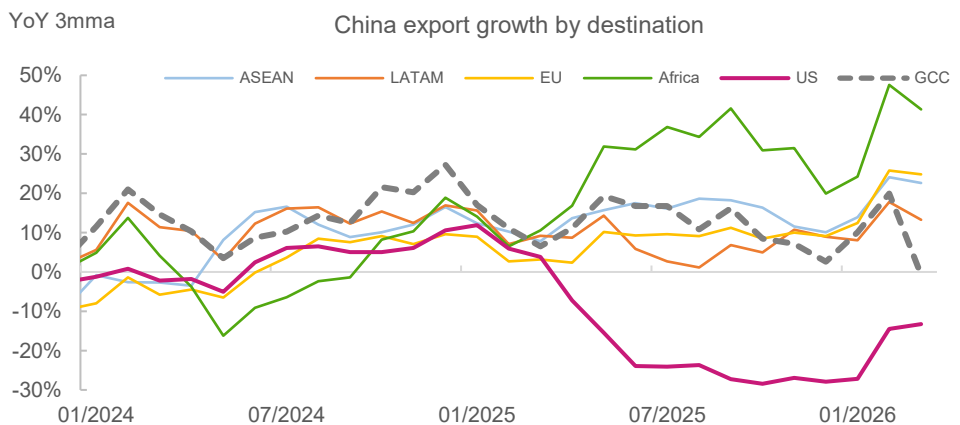
Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

China: still solid exports so far on global AI boom

Exports surged on global AI demand, despite rising headwinds

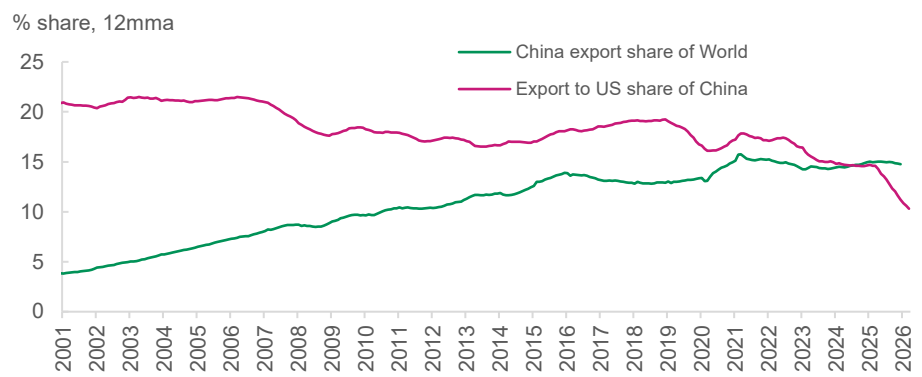
- China's exports surged in Q1 on AI-related products, auto and ships, though exports of final consumer products dragged. Exports to major destinations remained solid, while those to the US and Middle East dragged
- The negative impact on global growth would be more visible if the Iran conflict drags on, weighing on external demand for Chinese goods, even though China's share in global trade will likely remain at a relatively high level
- The contribution of net exports to growth will likely moderate in 2026, on likely slower external demand growth while China's domestic demand improves

China exports remained strong in Q1 though US and GCC dragged

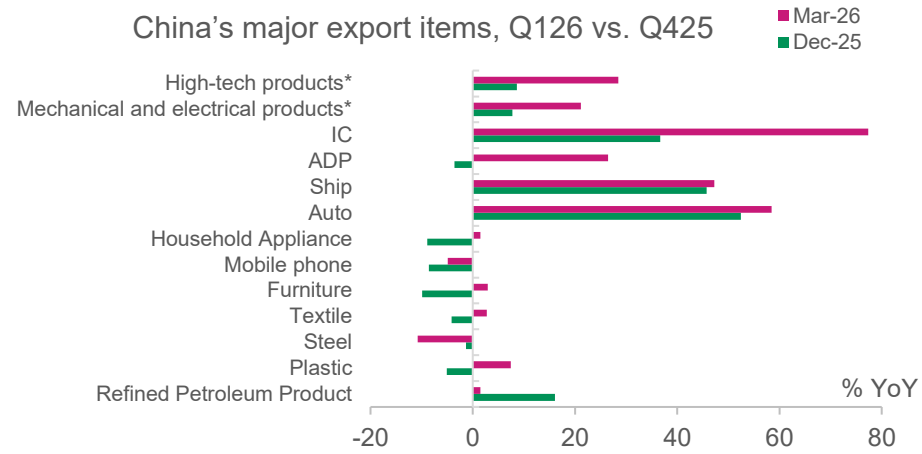


Source all charts: CEIC, China Customs, Crédit Agricole CIB

China's share in global exports remains high despite US tariffs



China's exports led by AI boom



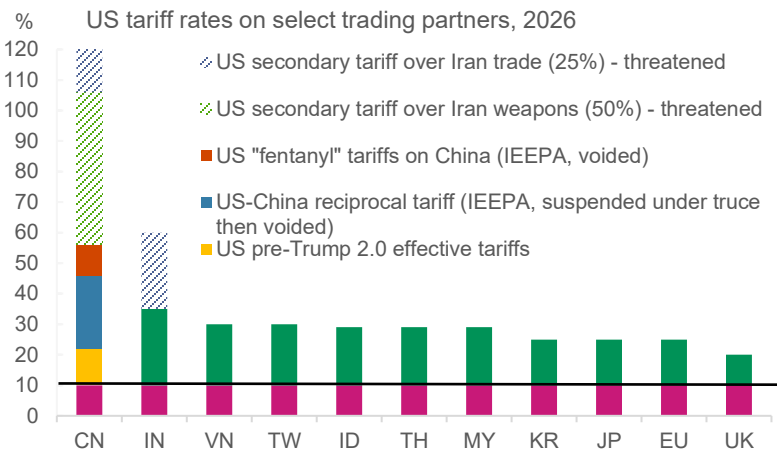
*High-tech products accounted for 25% of China exports, and mechanical and electrical products accounted for 61% of China exports in 2025

China: Trump-Xi summit – signals to stabilise bilateral ties

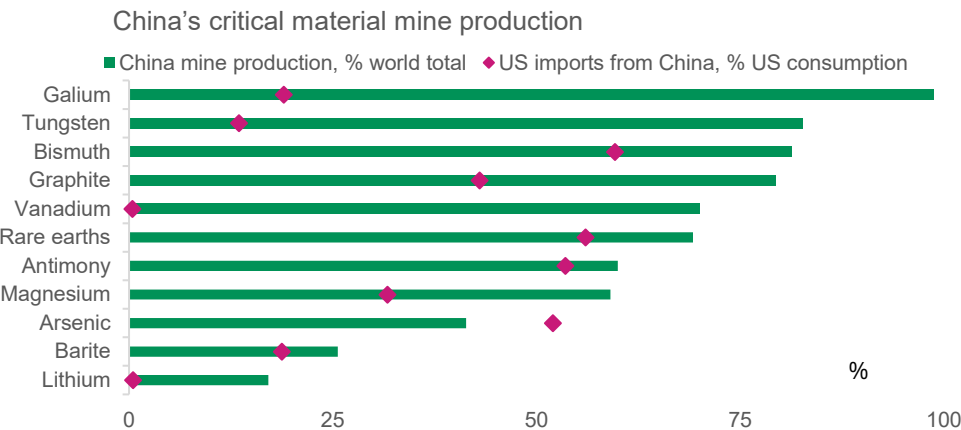
Tariffs, goods purchases, export controls and geopolitics

- Trump is scheduled to visit China on 14-15 May, following the latest US-China trade talks in Paris in March, with bilateral intentions to stabilise ties amid geopolitical and trade tensions
- Extension of trade truce, China purchase of US goods, stability of supply chain, the Middle East conflict and Taiwan are likely to be discussed
- Effective US tariff rates on China have been lowered by 10% to around 22% since February, though tariff uncertainties remain with ongoing US trade investigations

US tariffs on China notably lowered but threats remain



China's strong presence across a wide range of critical minerals



Topics	Major contention
US Section 301 Trade Investigations	China's "unfair trade practices" related to overcapacity and forced-labour, announced on 11 March
US Other Trade Investigations	China's permanent normal trade relations (PNTR) treatment
Existing US Trade Actions	Pre-IEEPA Section 232 and 301 tariffs remain unaffected
China Trade Investigations	US-China trade of "green products" and US measures that "disrupt global production and supply chains", announced on 27 March
Purchase of US Goods	US agricultural products (soybeans, sorghum), timber, Boeing jet deal
US Chip Export Controls China Import limits	US eased chip export controls to China to case-by-case review China approved 400k H200 chip imports (ByteDance, Alibaba, Tencent)
Taiwan	China seeks stronger US anti-independence stance on Taiwan US pending sale of USD11bn in arms to Taiwan
Iran	US strikes in Iran and current blockade in the Middle East US threatened 50% tariffs on Iranian trade partners/weapon suppliers

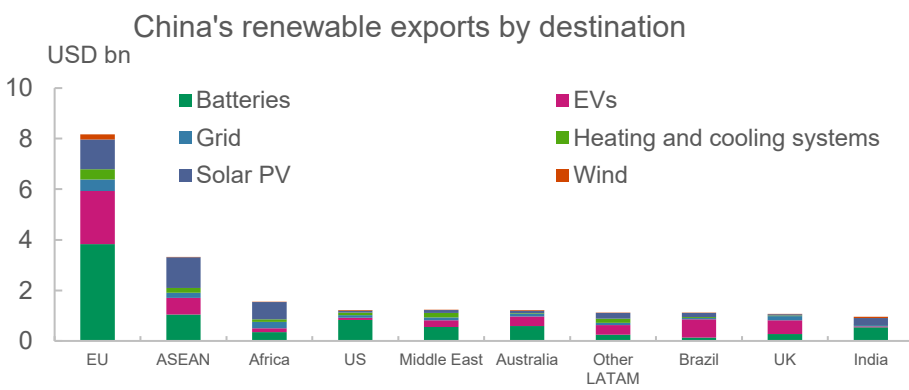
Source all charts: US Energy Information Administration (EIA), Bloomberg, CEIC, Cr dit Agricole CIB

China: leading renewable technology

Renewable technology can be a potential driver for China's export

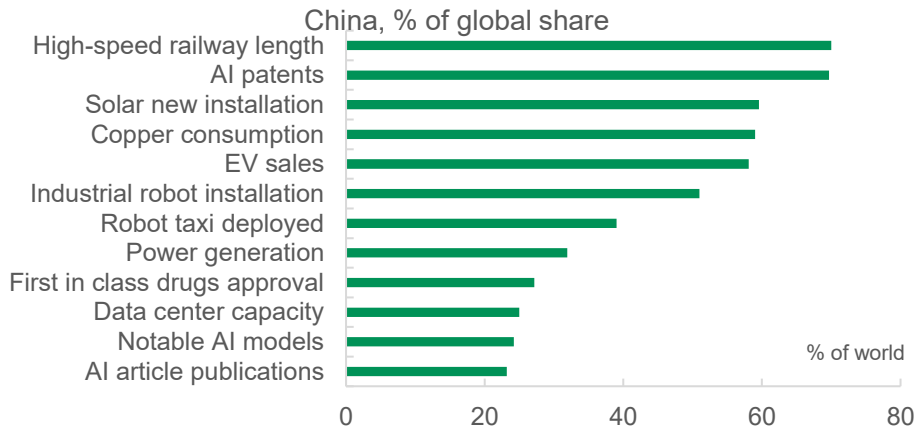
- China's strategy to push for technological breakthrough, develop advanced manufacturing and strengthen national security are structurally growth positive
- China is leading globally in renewable technology with dominant share in production of solar, lithium-ion batteries and EV
- After the Iran conflict, global demand for renewable energy products will likely strengthen further on energy security needs, benefiting China's related exports. However, trade barriers could also increase to reduce reliance on China

Global demand for China's renewable technology has been strong

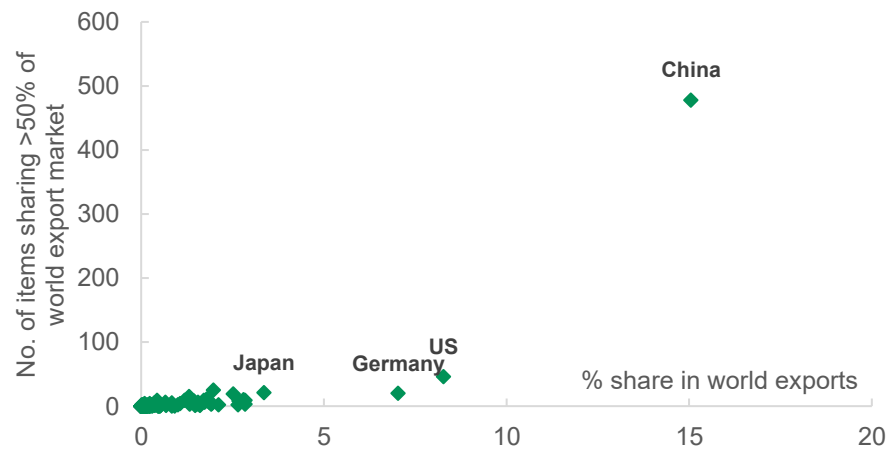


Source: National Bureau of Statistics of China, CEIC, Wind, Ember, Crédit Agricole CIB

China's rising significance in new infrastructure and industries



China's dominance in nearly 10% of globally traded goods

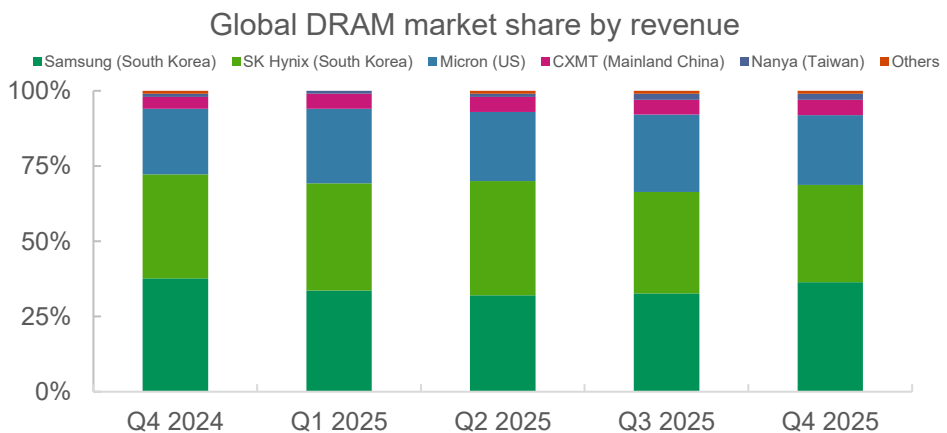


China: expanding role in global AI supply chain

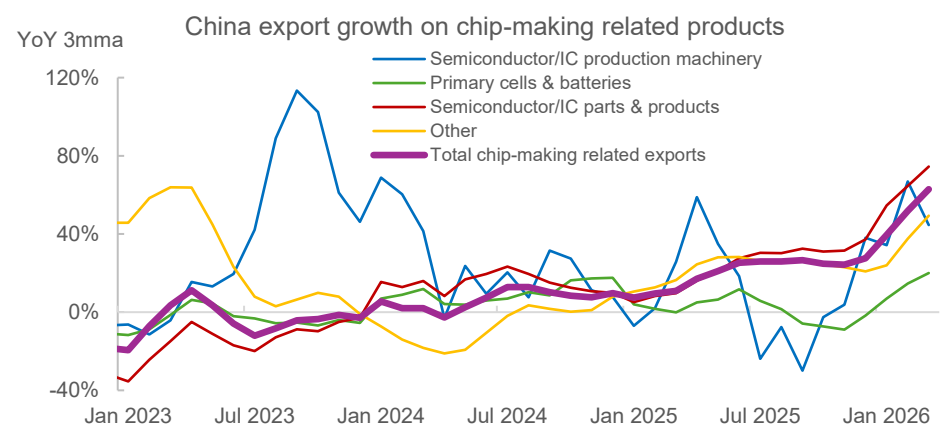
Global AI boom and China's expanding role in AI supply chain

- China has been increasingly a major player in AI, as it plays catch up with the US with its strong ambition to keep up with the global technology competition
- China leads in AI patents and is rich in research, talent and data. Empowered by its strong manufacturing base and vast market application, acceleration of AI adoption will drive China's capex and fosters productivity gains
- The global AI boom has been benefiting China's related exports, in upstream raw materials and mid-stream components and machinery & equipment. China AI models are rapidly grabbing global shares with its open source and cost efficiency

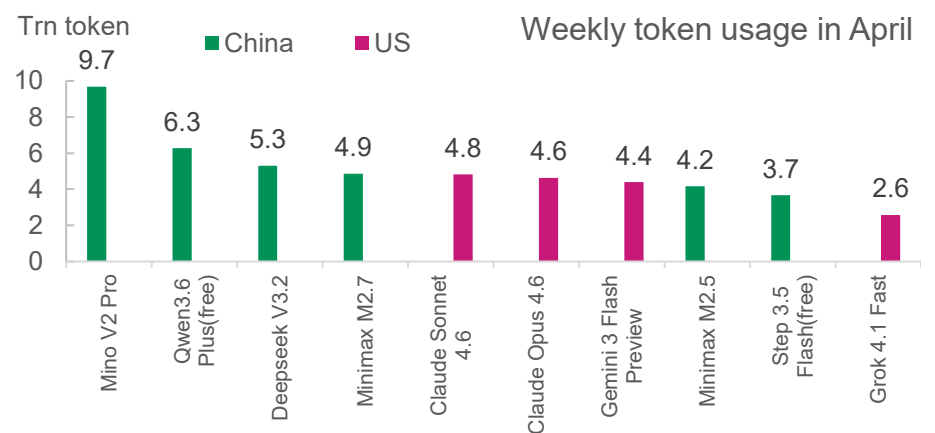
China's share in global advanced chips still small but with potential



Most of China's chip-making related exports edged up



China's AI models lead token consumption with its cost efficiency

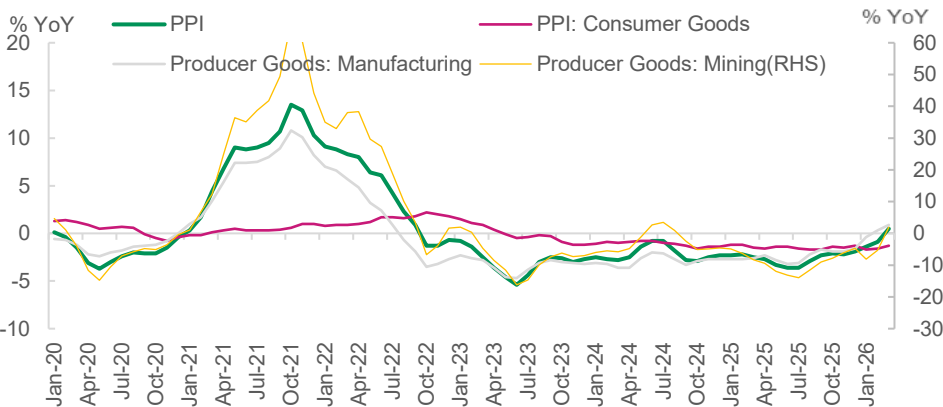


China: reflationary trend quickens in China, but still benign

Energy cost lifts PPI, but broader transmission stays contained

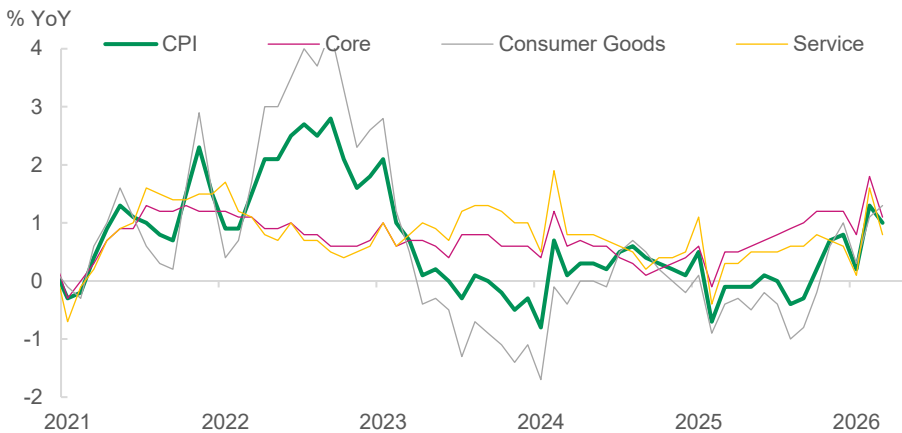
- Amid the Iran conflict, inflationary pressures are building up at early production stages, but with limited pass-through to downstream production and consumer prices, on continued softness in final demand growth
- We expect CPI inflation will rise to average 1.1% in 2026 from 0 in 2025, and PPI inflation could average 1.0% in 2026 vs -2.6% in 2025. GDP deflator will likely turn positive in Q2 after being negative in previous 12 quarters
- A prolonged Iran conflict could have more upward pressures on PPI with a broader impact beyond energy, while its boost to CPI would be benign

PPI turned to inflation in March on energy & raw materials prices

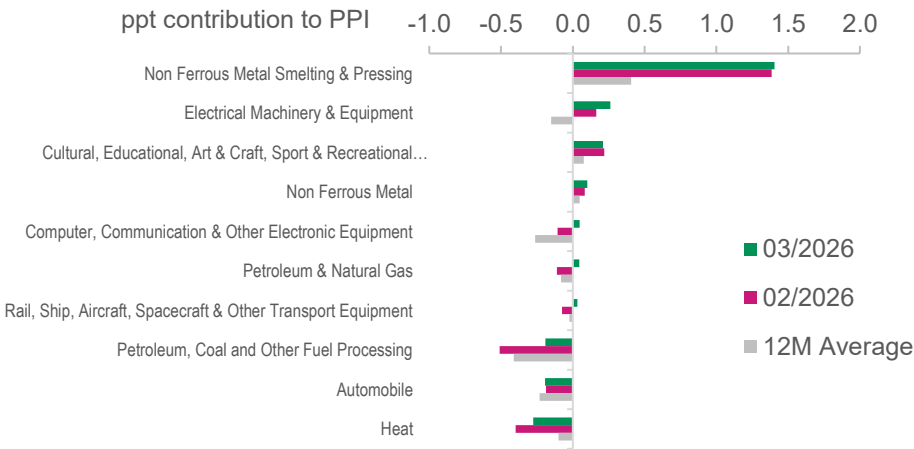


Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

Mild CPI reflation on its way



Non-ferrous metal and high-tech equipment drove PPI positive

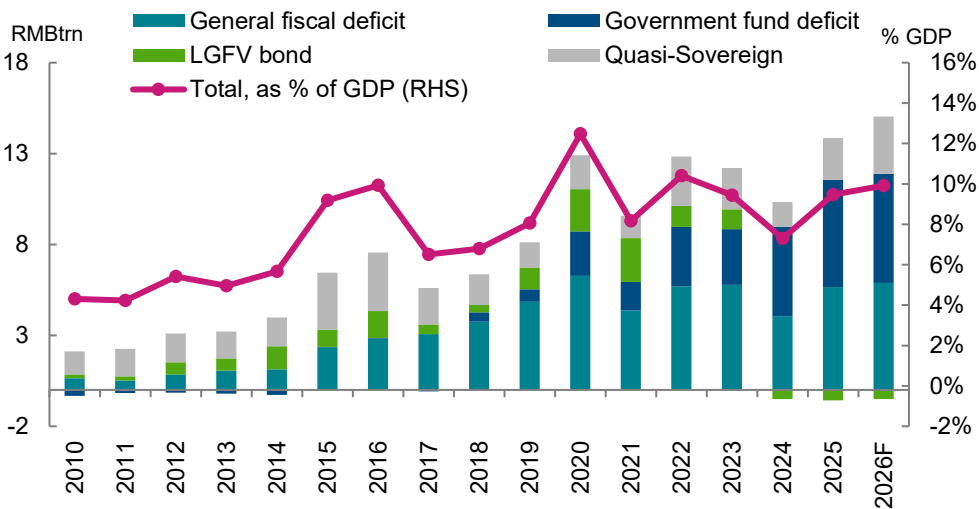


China: modest fiscal expansion with ample room to step up

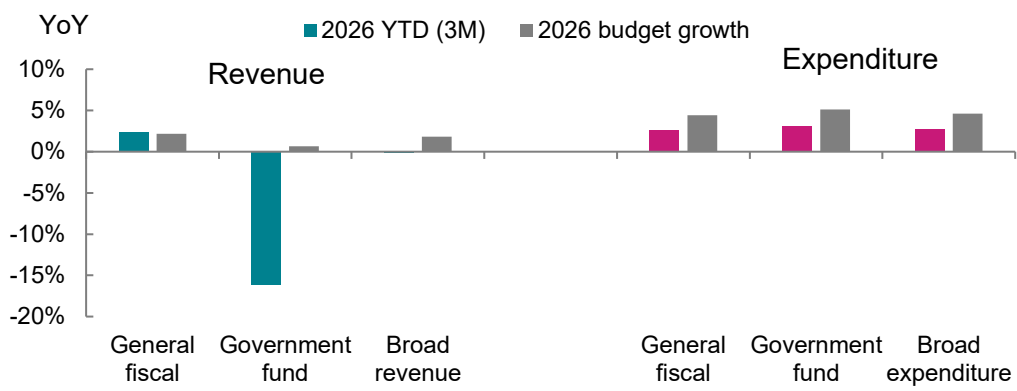
A modest fiscal expansion with room to expand against growth shocks

- China maintains a similar size of fiscal package in 2026 vs 2025, with a slightly smaller on-budget fiscal deficit ratio but likely larger fiscal spending via its quasi-fiscal measures
- A greater share of the fiscal resources is being allocated to investment, but subsidies for household income and consumption disappointed
- We expect China could boost its fiscal spending by 0.3-0.5% GDP later this year in case of major growth shocks

Augmented fiscal deficit ratio could pick up slightly



A modest fiscal improvement in Q126, but still behind budget



Expanding targeted support from central government funding

Category	Amount	Supporting areas
Central government budgetary investment	RMB755bn (vs 735bn in 2025)	Food & energy security, major strategic infrastructure, high-tech industries, ecological and environmental protection
Policy financing tools	RMB800bn (vs 500bn in 2025)	Digital economy, AI, low-altitude economy, green and low-carbon, infrastructure and public welfare projects
Coordinated fiscal-financial funds	RMB100bn (new in 2026)	Private business and consumption
Government industrial funds	National M&A fund (new in 2026) National VC guidance fund (founded in 2025, RMB100bn) National IC industry investment fund (Phase III founded in 2024, RMB344bn) National green development fund (founded in 2020, RMB89bn) National manufacturing transformation fund (founded in 2019, RMB147bn)	

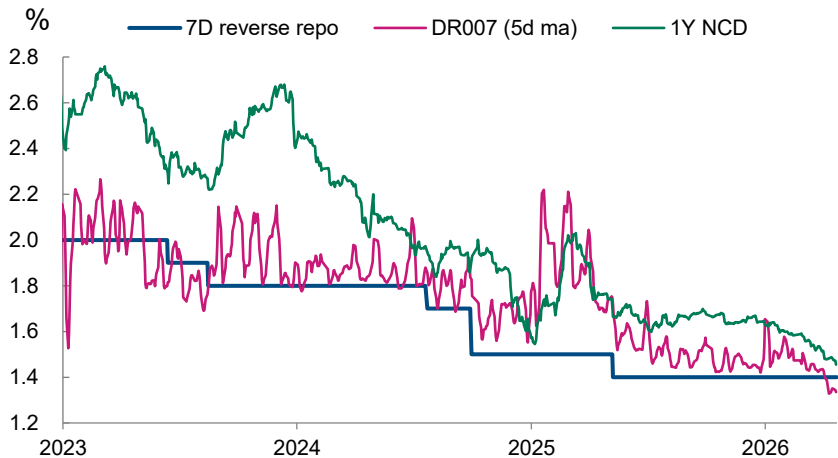
Source all charts: Government websites, Bloomberg, CEIC, Cr dit Agricole CIB

China: the PBoC to focus on targeted easing for now

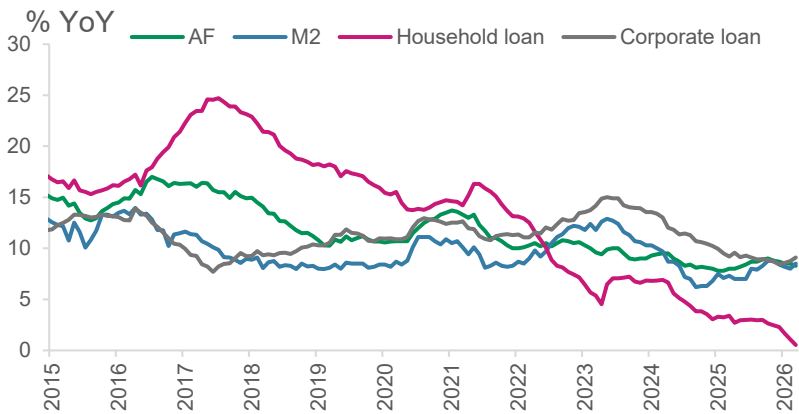
PBoC to stay in easing bias but with wait-and-see approach

- We do not think rising oil-led cost push inflation would turn the PBoC towards a neutral or even hawkish stance
- The PBoC will likely remain focused on structural supports to targeted sectors, and places a greater emphasis on managing stability across equity, bond and FX markets amid heightened global volatility
- Given the rapidly diminishing market expectations for Fed rate cuts, and increased FX volatility, the PBoC likely prefers a wait-and-see approach in policy rates

Ample liquidity conditions with DR007 dipping below policy rate



Credit growth further decelerated in early 2026



Structural policy tools to support targeted sectors

	Relending rate (1Y)	Relending quota (RMB)
2026	-25bp (to 1.25%) January	+400bn : technological innovation, industrial upgrades +500bn : agriculture, small business
2025	-25bp (to 1.50%) May	+300bn : agriculture, small business +300bn : technological innovation, industrial upgrades +500bn new : service consumption, elderly care
2024	-25bp (to 1.75%) January	+100bn : agriculture, small business +300bn new : affordable housing +500bn new : technological innovation, industrial upgrades +800bn new : stock buybacks and shareholding increases

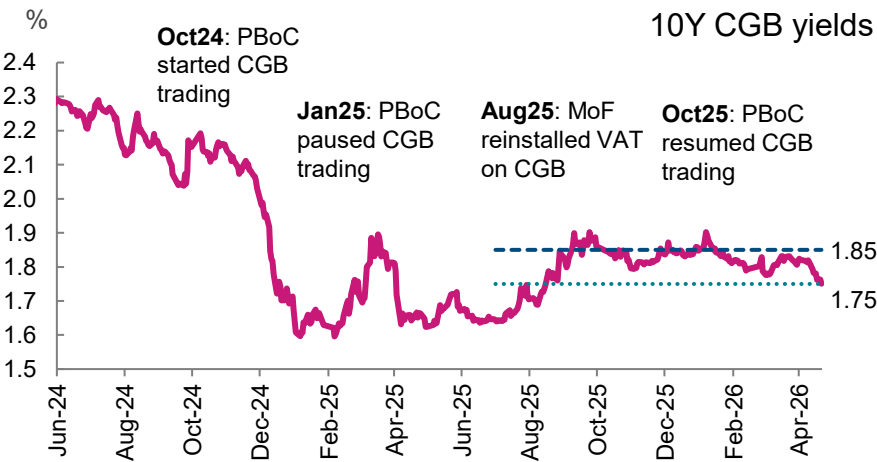
Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

China: dipping real yields to test the basics of bond demand

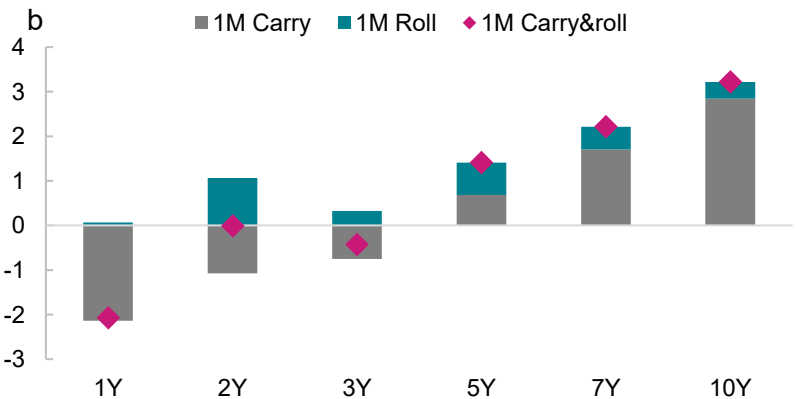
Less supports to further bull run of the bond market

- The 10Y CGB yield has declined to a YTD low of 1.75%, with real yield (0.75%) at its lowest level since 2023 against a gradual reflation progress
- The bull run in bond market since April was partially buoyed by ample liquidity, while bond demand has been decent with a lack of alternatives
- We maintain our view that the 10Y CGB yield could rebound modestly to the range of 1.85-1.95%, as nominal GDP growth picks up

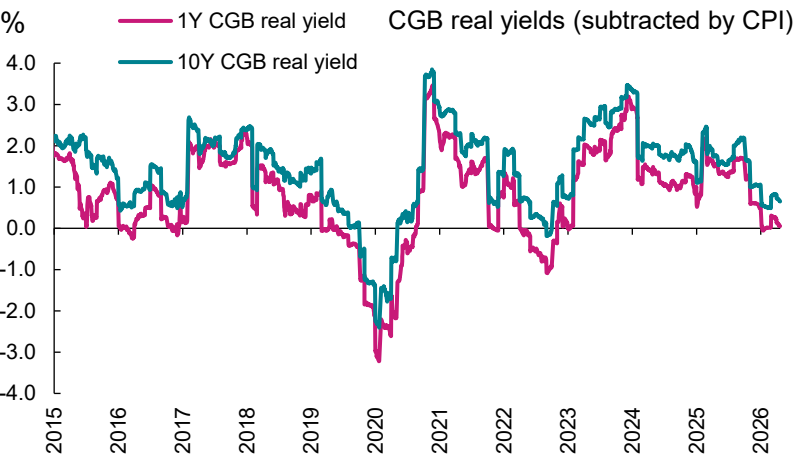
Is 10Y CGB yield breaking the range?



Investors are looking for carry and roll in the longer end of the curve



Real yields dipped to the lowest levels since 2023



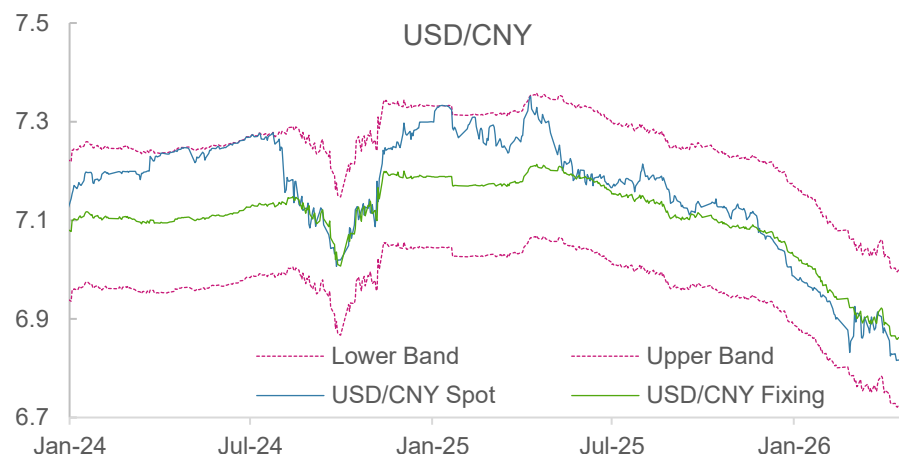
Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

China: the CNY to sustain its positive trajectory

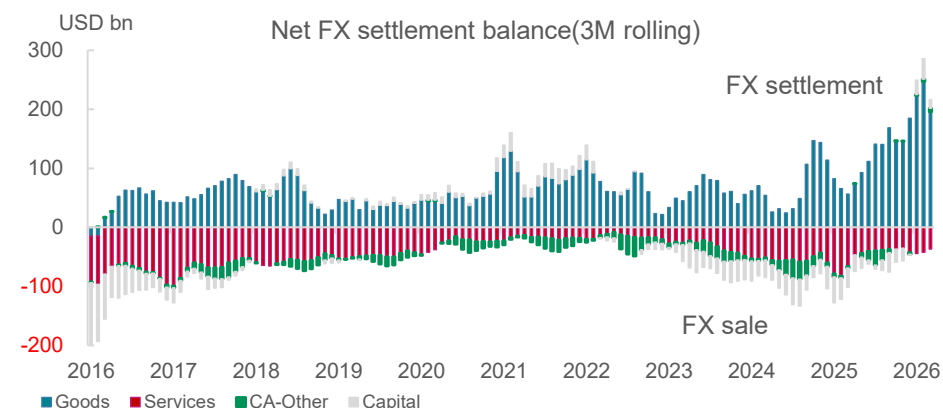
Positive policy signals reinforced by safe-haven demand

- China's export resilience, energy security, stabilised US-China relations have been supportive to onshore CNY demand
- The PBoC's willingness to have the CNY as a strong regional anchor and efforts to prevent excessive FX market volatility have kept the CNY insulated amid geopolitical uncertainties
- A more positive structural growth outlook and global diversification needs could lead to improving capital flows into China assets, in turn driving a mild appreciation trend of the CNY

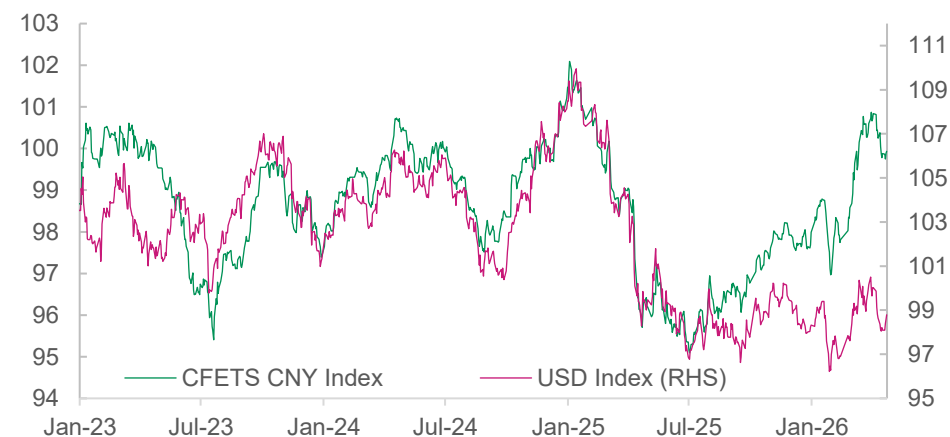
USD/CNY spot at its new low since 2023



Onshore FX settlement has strengthened significantly



CNY TWI remains elevated since the Iran conflict



Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

ASIA

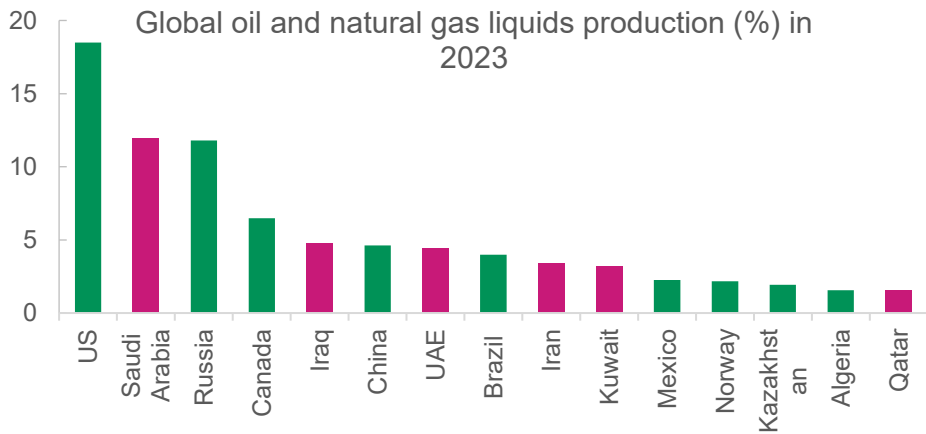
Caught in the cross-fire

Asia: taking stock of the Iran conflict

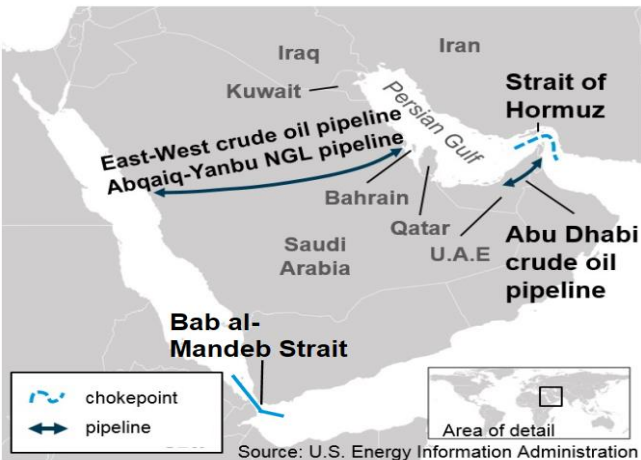
Asia vulnerable to Strait of Hormuz disruptions

- Since the US/Israel-Iran ceasefire announcement, markets have rallied in anticipation that US forces will soon withdraw.
- However, the Strait of Hormuz remains effectively closed with risks of potential geographic expansion to Red Sea shipping lanes, further energy and trade flows
- The majority of the Asian economies are net energy importers, except for Malaysia and Indonesia and hence are vulnerable to energy supply shocks

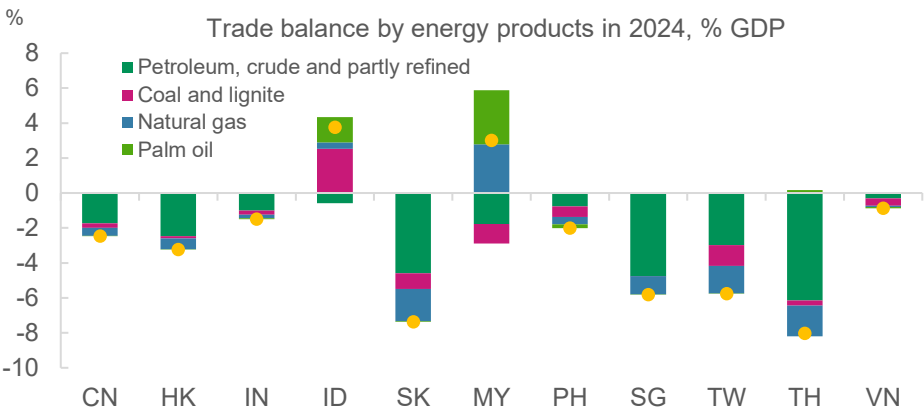
Middle East economies are major energy suppliers



The Strait of Hormuz remains a critical energy chokepoint...



Majority of the Asian economies are net energy importers



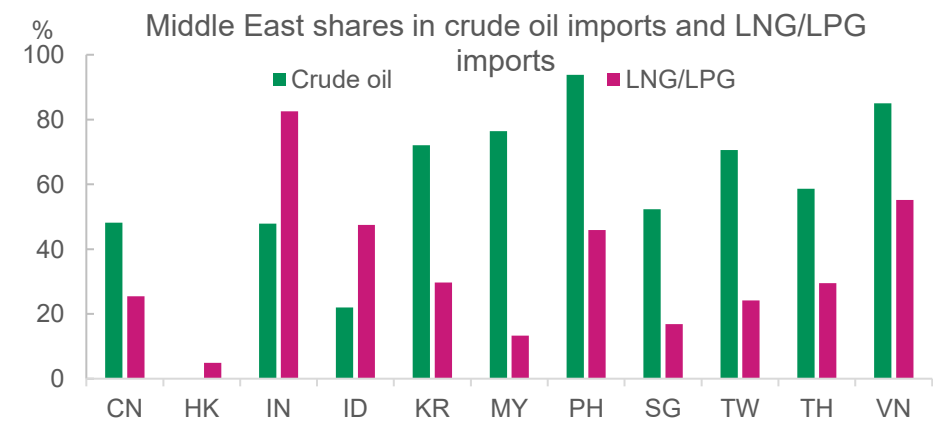
Source all charts: US Energy Information Administration (EIA), Bloomberg, CEIC, Cr dit Agricole CIB

Asia: unpacking the energy shock

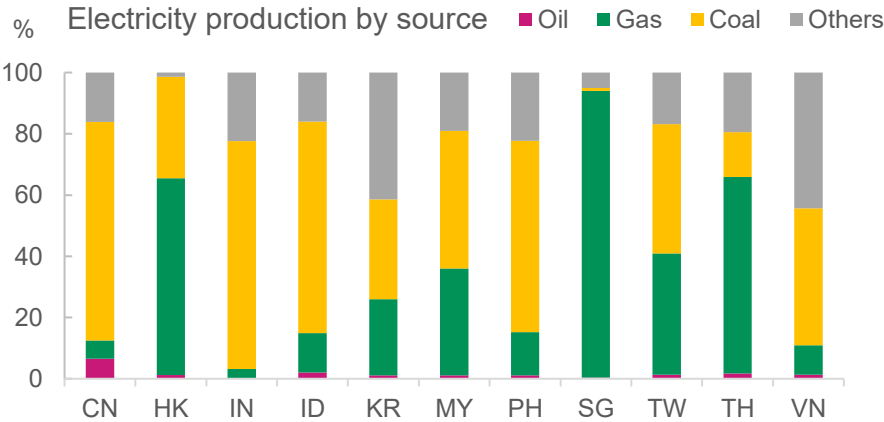
Oil shocks negative for Asia

- About 20% of global crude and 20% of global LNG transit the Strait of Hormuz, with Qatar (world's second largest LNG producer) a primary source of energy supply for many Asian economies
- Oil and gas reserves vary across economies, with better oil reserves for the North Asian economies, but in general low reserves for LNG reduces the buffer to protect against supply disruptions especially when it comes to electricity production
- Thailand & India look more vulnerable relative to China & Malaysia

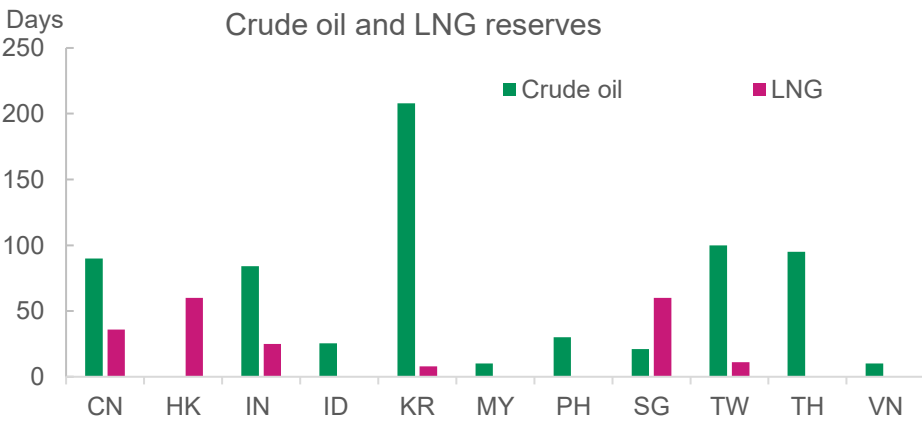
Material oil and gas reliance on Middle East for several Asian economies



LNG a risk for electricity production in Asia



Stockpiles are an important differentiating factor



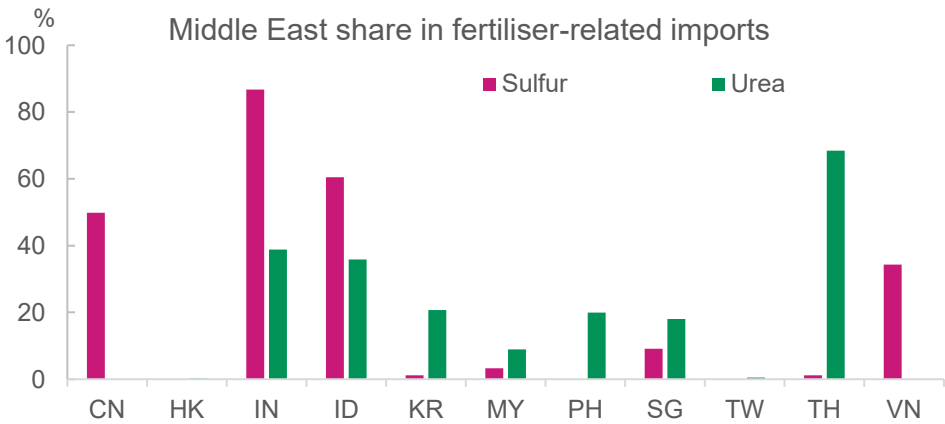
Source all charts: UN Comtrade, Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB, IEA

Asia: beyond energy, broader supply chain risk looms

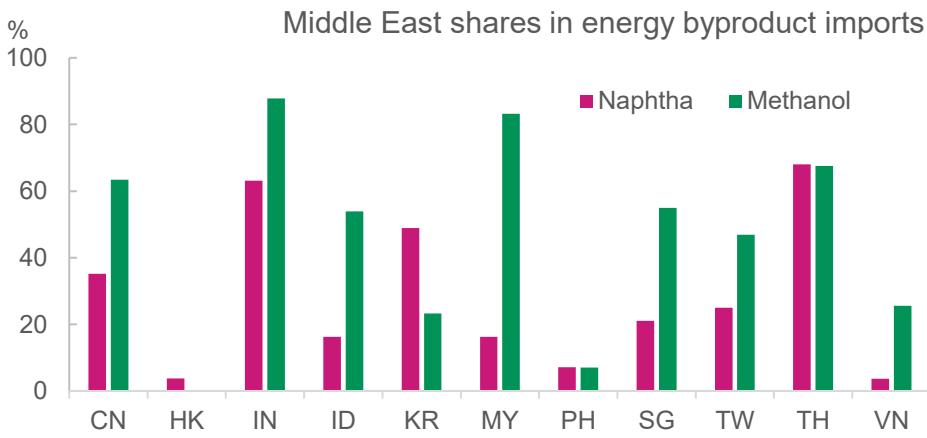
Broader supply chain risk looms

- Beyond the first wave of energy shocks, we are concerned about a broader impact on various supply chains
- Naphtha and methanol impact plastics, pharmaceuticals & construction materials
- Sulphur and urea impact fertilisers and food production
- Helium and aluminium impact semiconductor manufacturing and vehicle manufacturing

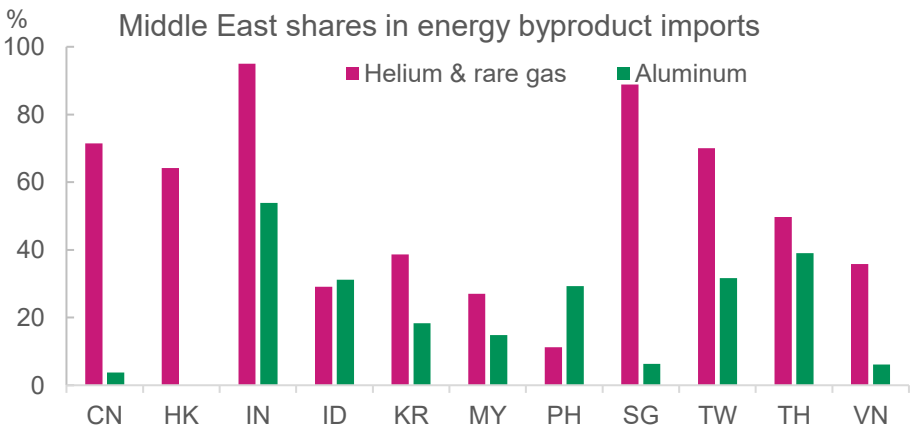
Fertiliser supply impacts food production and inflation



Middle East matters for various chemicals



Helium a key input into semiconductor manufacturing



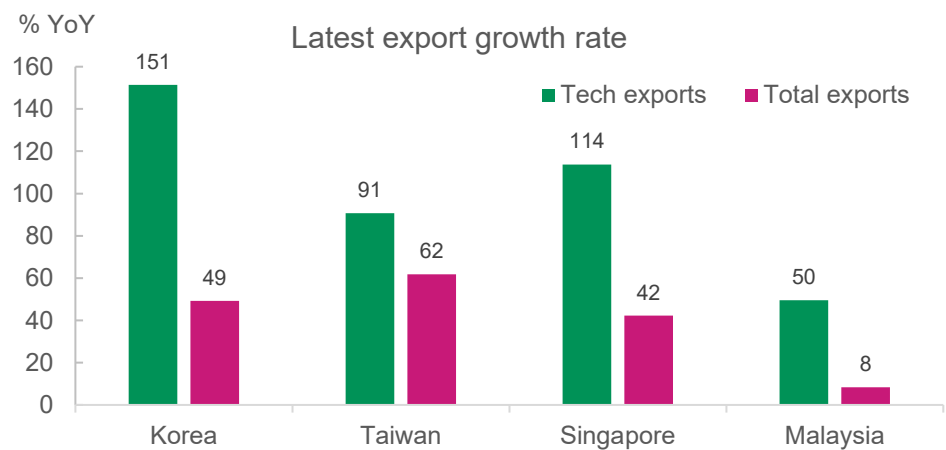
Source all charts: Statistics Korea, BOK, Bloomberg, CEIC, Cr dit Agricole CIB

Asia: disconnects and divergences

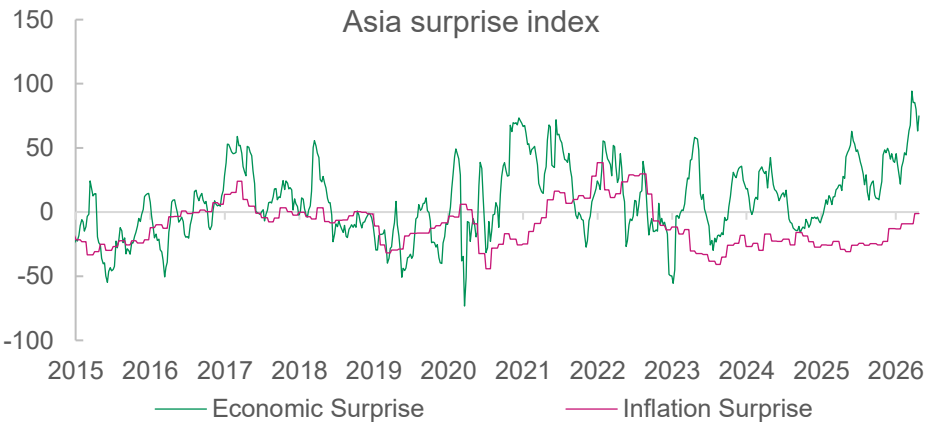
Underpricing demand destruction and inflation

- Data suggests impact from Iran is yet to really hit
- Strong momentum in tech exports has been a key driver of Asian growth so far in 2026. Positive sentiment around tech though assumes no supply disruptions materialise
- Even if conflict ends, it will take time to revert to 'normal'
- Trump's 301 tariffs expected to be finalised by July 2026 resulting in renewed higher tariff rates again will also pose a headwind to growth

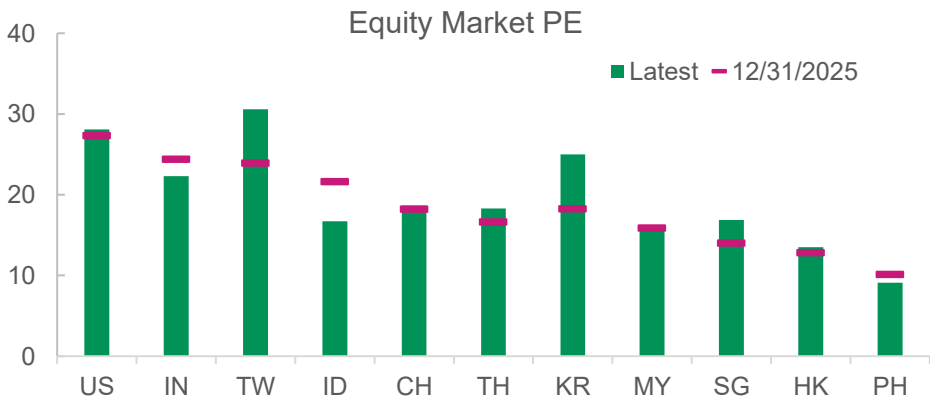
Strong tech exports a driver of resilience



EM data is holding up well so far



Will shortages sap Asia tech momentum?



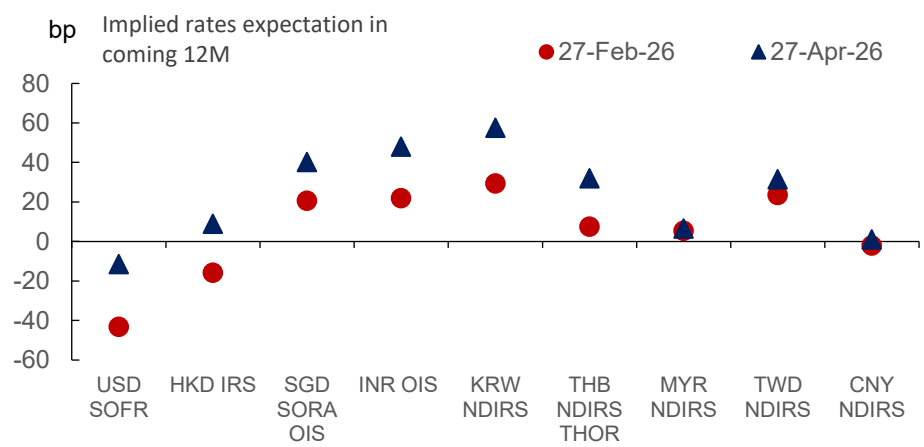
Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

Asia: implications for Asia rates and FX

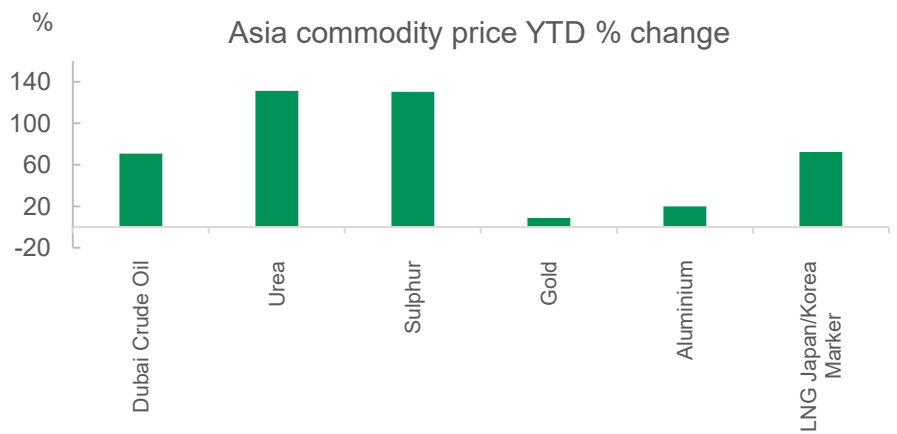
More pressure to come?

- Governments are pushing to slow down the impact of import inflation from Iran, but that will inevitably come
- Soaring energy prices have fuelled inflation concerns and hawkish repricing of Asia rates though some overshooting seen
- Energy inflation concerns combined with expanding fiscal deficits could put upward pressure on long-term government bond yields
- Iran conflict negative for major Asia FX given negative terms-of-trade shock and global risk-off sentiment

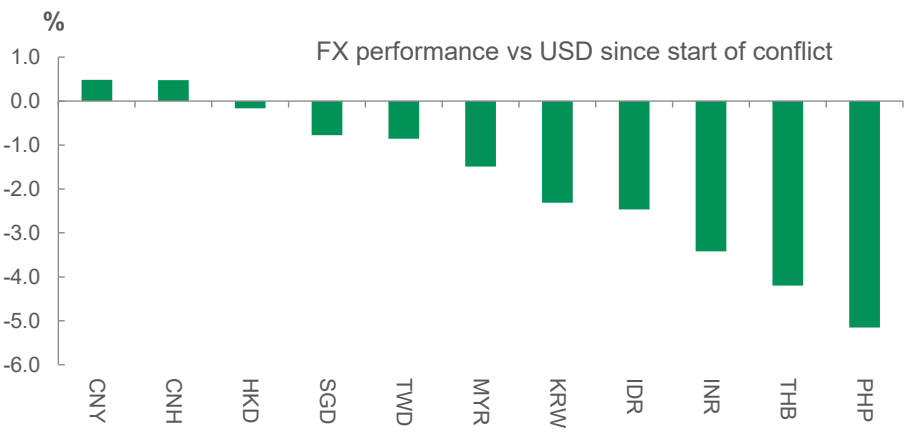
Rates markets turned more hawkish



Inflation targets could be tested ahead



Iran conflict has weighed on Asia (ex-China) FX



Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

HONG KONG

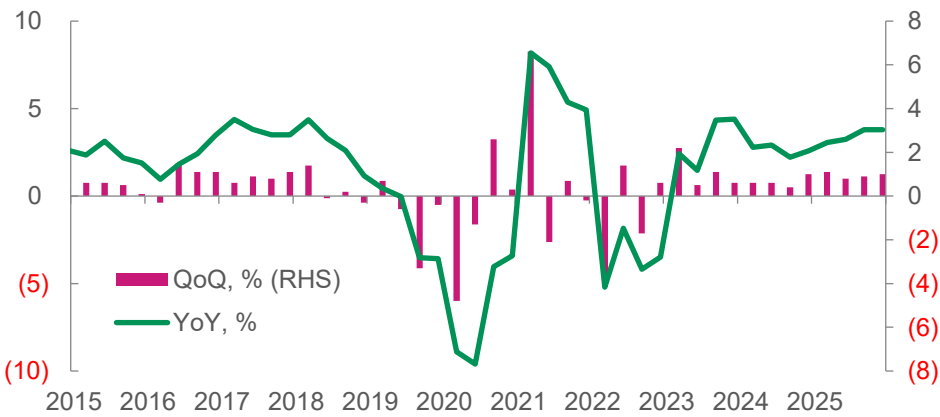
Recovering ground

Hong Kong: positive 2025 momentum to carry into 2026

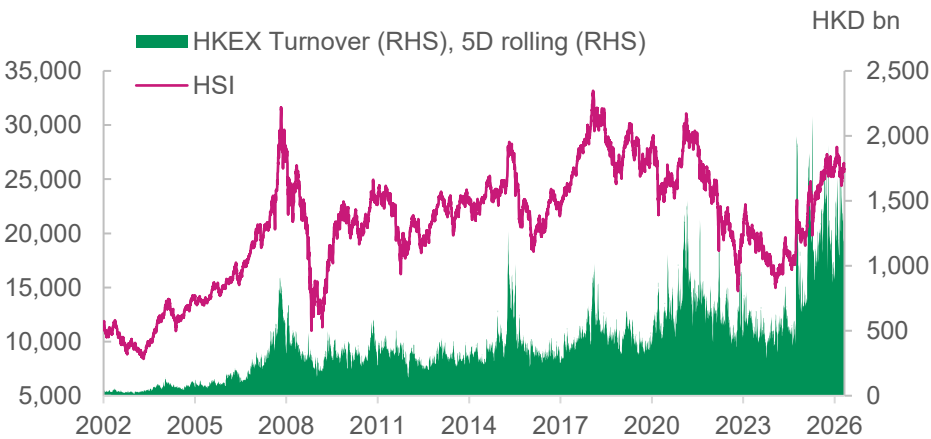
Mounting a comeback

- Economy making robust recovery driven by strong exports of goods and services, modest private consumption recovery and investment growth amid trade tensions
- Domestic demand to remain resilient in 2026 amid wealth effect while trade to remain a key growth engine
- 2026 GDP to remain above potential at 3.1%

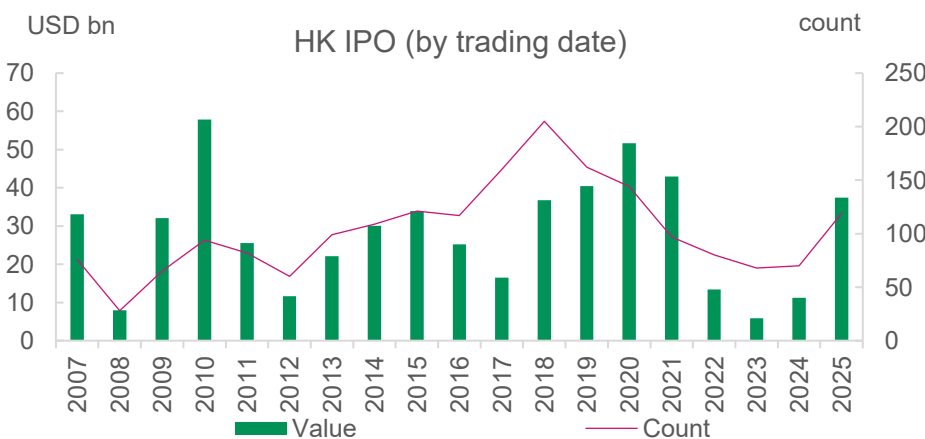
HK economy growing robustly



Equity market still buoyant



IPOs a key driver of investor interest



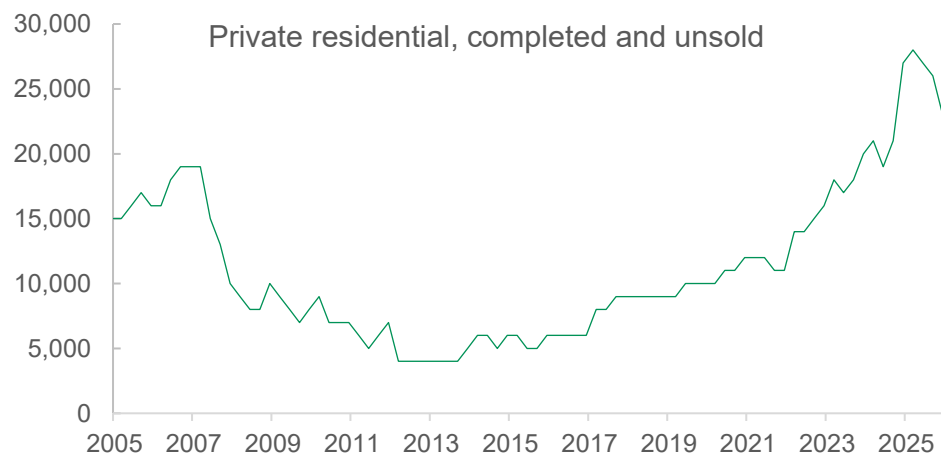
Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

Hong Kong: property market on the mend

Turnover and prices both rising

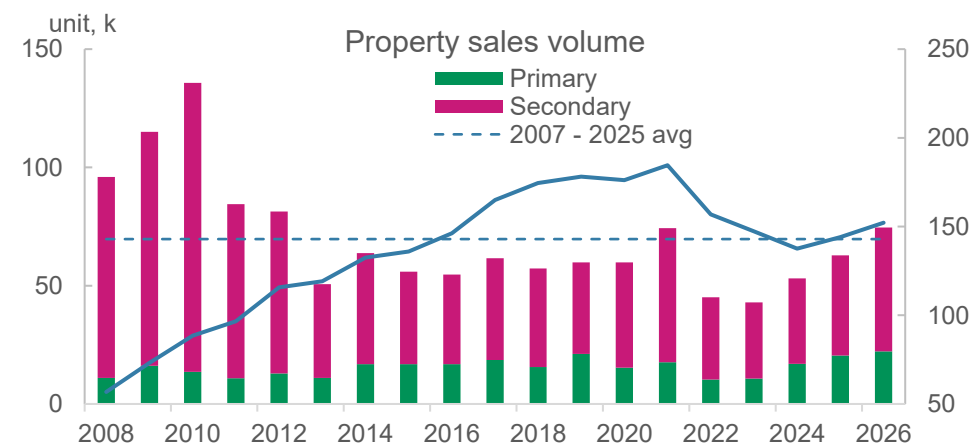
- The turnover in the property market is another source of wealth effect for local residents
- Increase in population and household growth helped by talent inflows
- High rental costs, lower borrowing costs and eased cooling measures leading to a pickup in interest in primary and luxury market
- Local developers are seeing a strong pickup in interest as investor confidence picks up

Housing inventories still high but easing

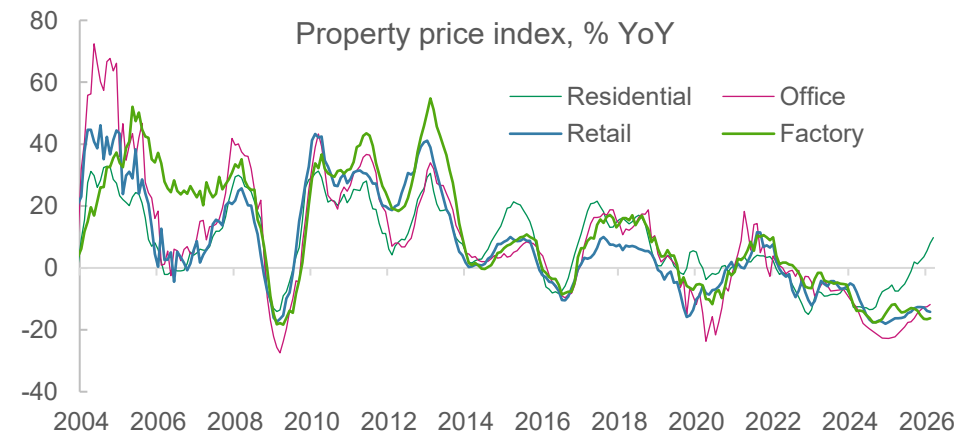


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Property market turnover rebounding significantly



Property prices has room to climb higher

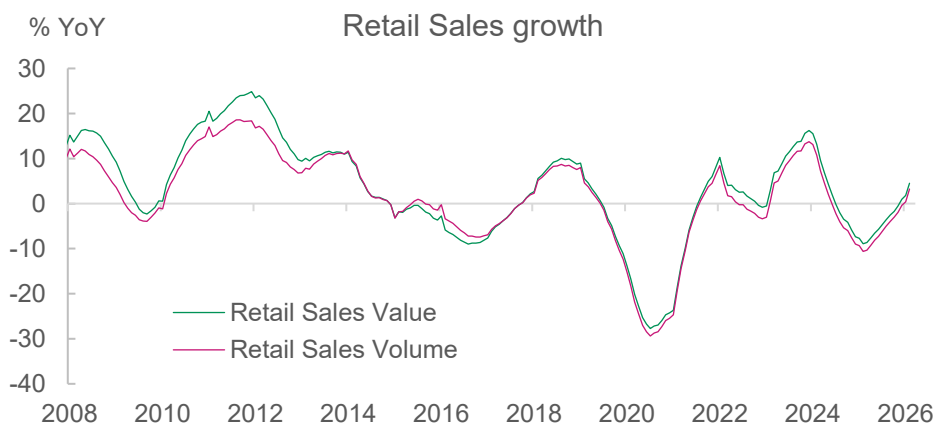


Hong Kong: strengthening foundation for growth

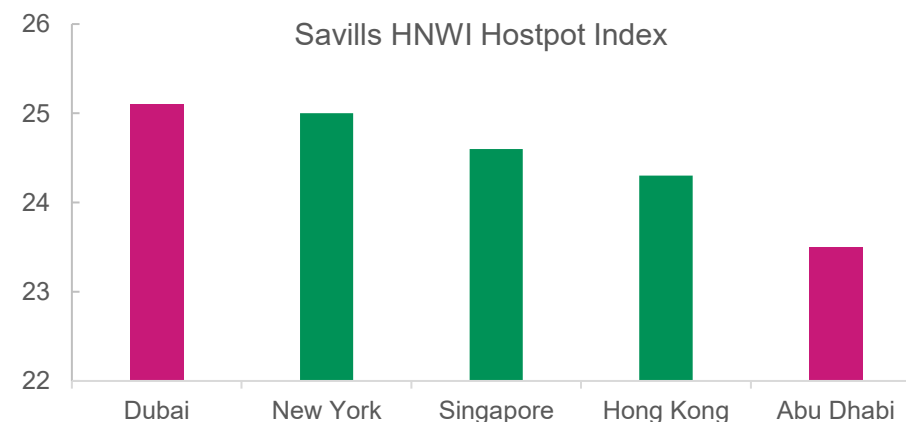
Strengthening the base

- Hong Kong could capitalise from a pickup in inflows (both financial and talent) as a result of Iran conflict
- City remains at the forefront of RMB internationalisation and fintech efforts which burnishes its financial centre appeal
- Improved fiscal position and cyclical tailwinds allowing the government to raise expenditures and accelerate development of Northern Metropolis

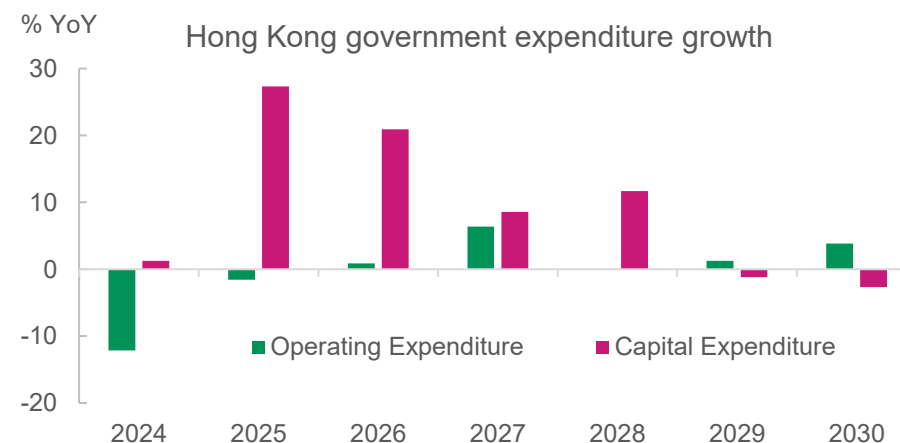
Retail sales edging up slowly though still dispersed



Opportunities for Hong Kong from Middle East conflict



Government ramping up capital works expenditure



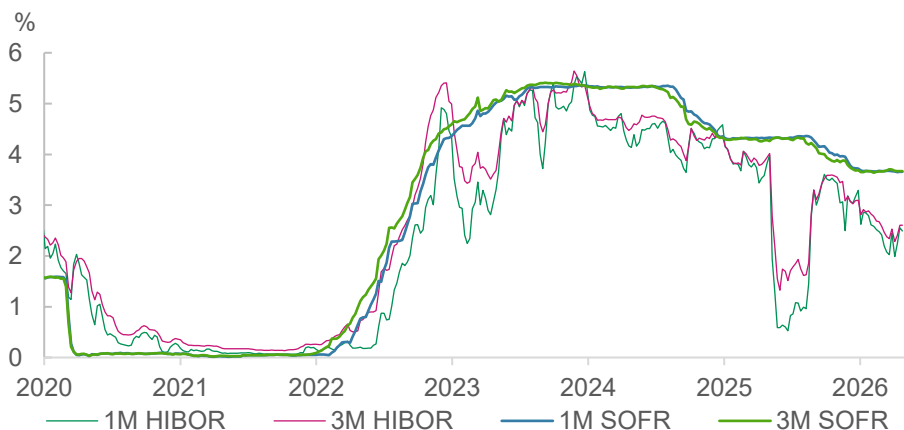
Source all charts: Savills, Bloomberg, CEIC, Cr dit Agricole CIB

Hong Kong: carry still supporting USD/HKD

Carry still in the driving seat

- Wide US-HK interest rate differentials continue to favour long USD/HKD positioning
- Local HKD interest rates gap with USD interest rates has increased amid flush liquidity conditions with market pricing out Fed rate cuts
- The buildup of USD money market fund AUM in Hong Kong is another sign that investors continue to favour carry

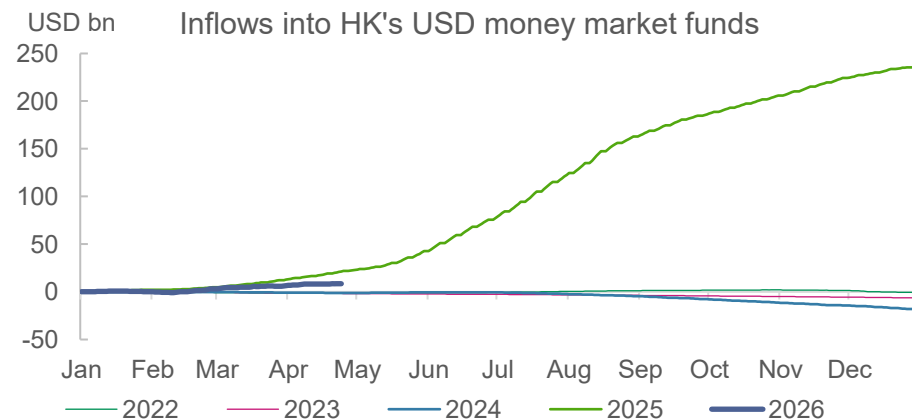
Widening US-HK rate gap incentivises carry



USD/HKD still supported



USD money market fund AUM still rising



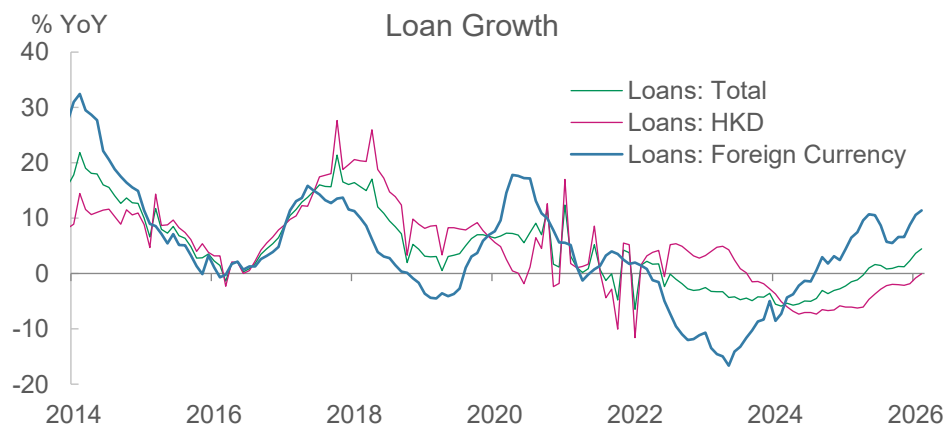
Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

Hong Kong: watching HKD financing trends

Slowly turning a corner

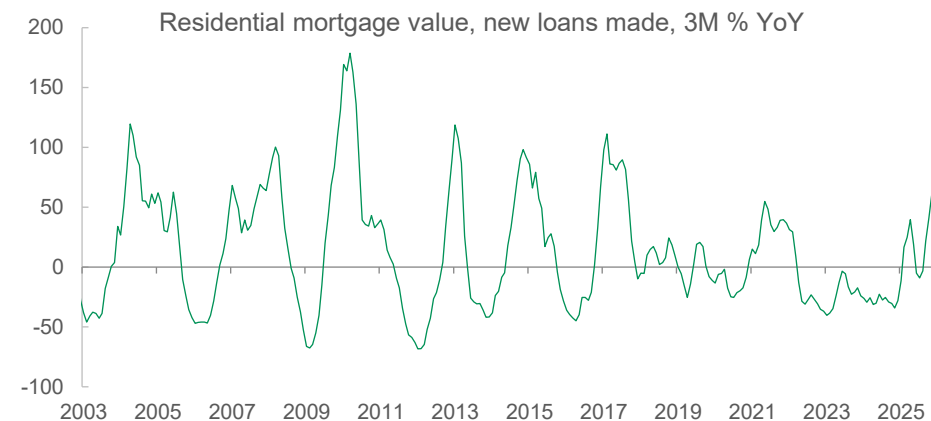
- State of loan market in HK can impact of Hong Kong liquidity dynamics
- Residential loan growth has picked up driven by professional investors
- Subdued HKD loan growth overall though suggests that a more sustained turnaround in the economy is still needed
- In the meantime, surge in Hong Kong bond market issuance could also weigh on the HKD market if funds are repatriated out after issuance

HKD loan growth out of contraction territory

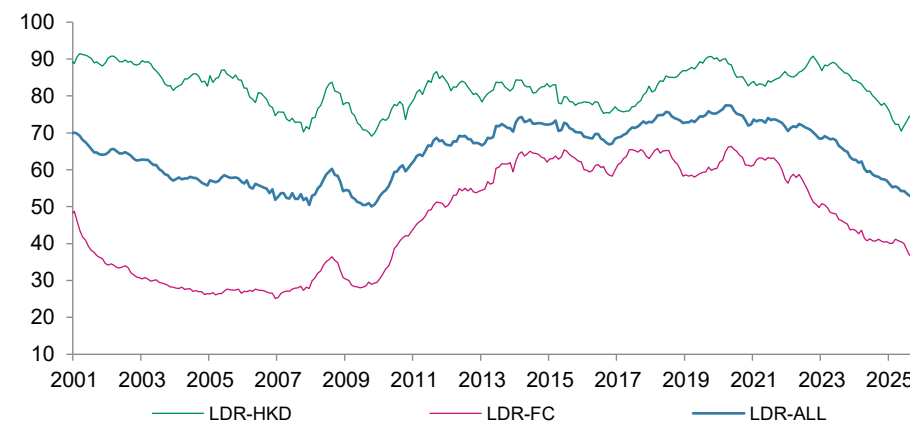


Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Cr dit Agricole CIB

Residential loan growth at fastest rate since 2023



But loan-to-deposit ratio yet to bottom

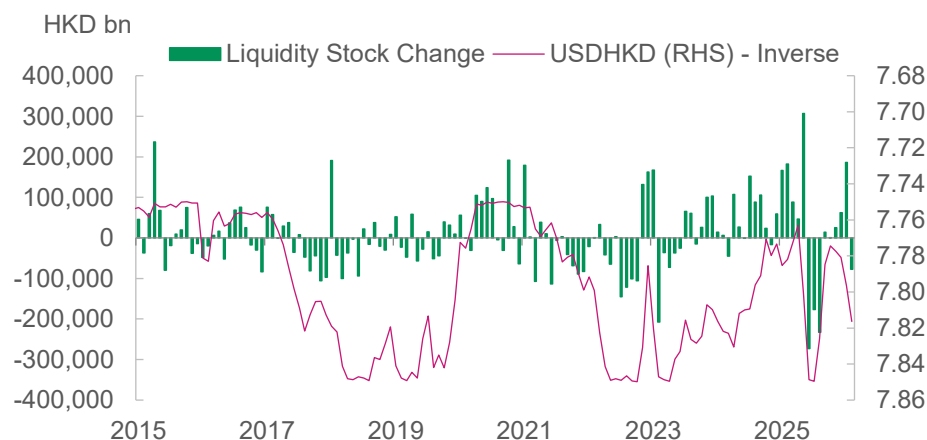


Hong Kong: the HKD and the tug of war

Higher USD/HKD to narrow US-HK rate gap

- Equity sentiment remains an important wildcard though elevated geopolitical risks could keep sentiment modest
- Hot IPOs though could still trigger temporary bouts of liquidity squeezes alongside other factors like seasonality (ie, dividend flows)
- Expect drift higher in USD/HKD towards 7.85 with slow drain of aggregate balance though HKD44bn to be a floor
- This will narrow the US-HK rate gap and weaken carry allowing inflows to support HKD in the medium term

Equity flow dynamics will be important

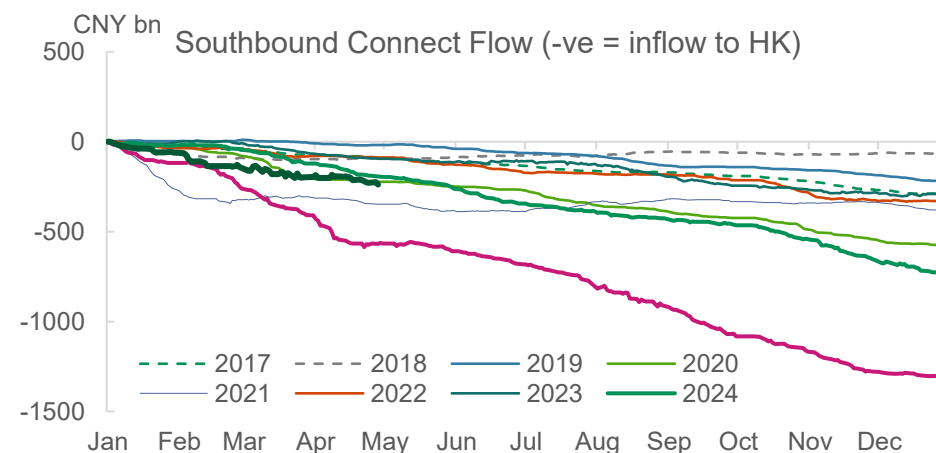


Source all charts: Bloomberg, CEIC, Crédit Agricole CIB

Hong Kong liquidity loose but beware periodic episodes



Southbound flows also less aggressive than before



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